

Small Batches at IMVU

At IMVU, we applied these lessons from manufacturing to the way we work. Normally, new versions of products like ours are released to customers on a monthly, quarterly, or yearly cycle.

Take a look at your cell phone. Odds are, it is not the very first version of its kind. Even innovative companies such as Apple produce a new version of their flagship phones about once a year. Bundled up in that product release are dozens of new features (at the release of iPhone 4, Apple boasted more than 1,500 changes).

Ironically, many high-tech products are manufactured in advanced facilities that follow the latest in lean thinking, including small batches and single-piece flow. However, the process that is used to design the product is stuck in the era of mass production. Think of all the changes that are made to a product such as the iPhone; all 1,500 of them are released to customers in one giant batch.

Behind the scenes, in the development and design of the product itself, large batches are still the rule. The work that goes into the development of a new product proceeds on a virtual assembly line. Product managers figure out what features are likely to please customers; product designers then figure out how those features should look and feel. These designs are passed to engineering, which builds something new or modifies an existing product and, once this is done, hands it off to somebody responsible for verifying that the new product works the way the product managers and designers intended. For a product such as the iPhone, these internal handoffs may happen on a monthly or quarterly basis.

Think back one more time to the envelope-stuffing exercise. What is the most efficient way to do this work?

At IMVU, we attempted to design, develop, and ship our new features one at a time, taking advantage of the power of small batches. Here's what it looked like.

Instead of working in separate departments, engineers and designers would work together side by side on one feature at a time. Whenever that feature was ready to be tested with customers,